Lesson 46: Academic Voice and Clarity

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 6.1 Introduction; 6.2 Sample Student Research Essay Draft: Food Deserts; 6.3 Finding Your Academic Voice; 6.4 Writing with Clarity; 6.6 Using Clear Pronoun References.

In this lesson

You will read a student's rough draft of a research essay on food deserts and use it to study two features of clear academic writing: an academic voice and clear pronoun references. You will compare an informal and an academic version of the same introduction and revise unclear pronouns. Clear, focused writing lets your reader, including the reader of a psychology paper, follow your ideas without extra effort.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Describe the main features of an academic voice in U.S. English writing.
- Explain why one version of a text is more academic than another.
- Name four strategies for writing with clarity.
- Find pronouns and their antecedents, and revise references that are unclear.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
clarity	the quality of being clear and easy to understand	Writing clear, precise sentences will help your audience understand your message.
academic voice	the style of college writing: clear, specific, focused on one topic, mostly third person, built on sources	Academic writing does not come naturally to most people.
third-person voice	writing about others (people, researchers, it, they), not about I or you	This phenomenon has become especially evident as people pay more attention to a healthy diet.
unity	staying focused on the main topic	Build unity and coherence by staying focused on the main topic at hand.
hook	an opening that gets the reader interested in the topic	Have you ever wondered why there are no supermarkets in certain areas?

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
phe·NOM·e·non (pl. phenomena)	an event or situation that can be observed	This phenomenon has become especially evident...
food desert	an area with limited access to affordable, healthy foods	Many residents live in areas known as food deserts.
so·ci·o·e·co·NOM·ic status	a person's position in society, based on income, education and work	It is difficult for some people of lower socioeconomic status to access healthy food.
rough draft	an early, unfinished version of a text	This sample is a rough draft that is not intended to be a model of a polished, finished essay.
pronoun	a word that takes the place of a noun	he, she, it, they, this, these, them, those
antecedent	the noun that a pronoun refers to	Many people started shopping at the new supermarket when it opened, but they weren't buying much produce. (people = antecedent of they)

Rules and explanations

Why clarity matters

Readers should not have to work too hard to understand your message. If your writing distracts them, they may lose interest or misunderstand your ideas, and in an argument they may be less likely to agree with you. A clear, well-written argument may convince skeptical readers to change their minds.

The model: a rough draft

This lesson and the next use a student's rough draft, "Accessibility and Affordability of Healthy Food Dependent Upon Socioeconomic Status" by Amanda Wu. California's Central Valley is known as "the salad bowl" of the nation, yet many Californians live in food deserts. Amanda's draft is the "before" version: you will advise her on clarity and style, then apply the same strategies to your own writing.

Finding your academic voice

To write in the U.S. English academic style:

- use clear, specific word choice and sentence constructions (including active voice as much as possible: Lesson 47);
- build unity and coherence by staying focused on the main topic;
- use mostly the third person to build your argument: incorporate outside sources, and mostly avoid personal experience and discussion of your process of writing the paper.

Academic writing does not come naturally to most people, native speakers of English or not. It is usually best to apply these ideas after you finish a full draft: when your thesis and support are clear, it is much easier to clarify your sentences.

In psychology (APA style): APA style accepts the first person for your own actions as a writer or researcher ("I argue", "we tested"), because it is clearer than an awkward passive. Personal stories and the other points above still apply.

Four strategies for clarity

1. avoiding wordiness
2. choosing active voice where appropriate
3. using clear pronoun references (below)
4. using strong and specific rather than general words

Strategies 1, 2 and 4 are in Lesson 47.

Clear pronoun references

- A **pronoun** (he, she, it, they, this, these, them, those…) takes the place of a noun. Its **antecedent** is the noun it refers to. Like a price tag on a supermarket shelf, a pronoun must point directly to its item.
- *If residents can make good use of food hubs or community gardens, they can access healthy food and learn how to grow fresh vegetables and fruits themselves.* (residents = antecedent of they and themselves)
- Each pronoun needs **a single, clear antecedent**. A reference is unclear when two nouns could be the antecedent, especially when the wrong one is closer to the pronoun.
  - Unclear: *Some researchers suggest that the idea food deserts exist because a lack of demand for healthy foods by patrons is flawed; they are taking another look at this narrative.* (They could be researchers or patrons, and patrons is closer.)
  - Clearer: *…; these researchers are taking another look at this narrative.*
- To fix an unclear reference, repeat the noun, often with this or these.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic pronouns show gender even for things, which helps the reader find the antecedent. English it and they have no gender, so they can point to almost any noun: check that only one noun could match. - Arabic relative clauses often contain a pronoun that refers back to the noun. English relative clauses do not: write "the food that people buy", not "the food that people buy it".

Practice

Exercise 1: Reading the draft. Read "Accessibility and Affordability of Healthy Food Dependent Upon Socioeconomic Status" by Amanda Wu in the lesson material. It has six paragraphs.

1. What is the thesis statement?
2. What two difficulties do paragraphs 2 and 3 explain?
3. Paragraph 4 discusses another perspective. What is it, and which words signal the other perspective, the concession and Amanda's response?

4. What two solutions does paragraph 5 describe? Give one example of each.
5. Find two hedged claims in the conclusion (paragraph 6).

Exercise 2: Analyzing academic voice. Which of these excerpts from Amanda's introduction best fits the definition of effective academic writing? Why?

1. Have you ever had trouble finding a supermarket when you wanted to get fresh vegetables and fruits? Have you ever wondered why there are no supermarkets in certain areas? I've noticed these things happening as people have begun to pay more attention to eating and buying healthy things. Last year a Whole Foods opened in my neighborhood.
2. Have you ever had trouble finding a supermarket when you wanted to purchase fresh vegetables and fruits? Have you ever wondered why there are no supermarkets in certain areas? This phenomenon has become especially evident as people pay more attention to a healthy diet and lean towards purchasing healthy food.

Exercise 3: Pronouns and antecedents in action. Look at the second paragraph of Amanda's essay in section 6.6 of the lesson material. Focus on the first and third sentences (in brackets).

1. Find the pronouns and their antecedents. Are the relationships between them clear?
2. Is there anything Amanda could further clarify?

Exercise 4: Revising unclear references. These sentences are from Amanda's draft. For each one, say what the pronoun in bold should refer to and why the reference is unclear. Then revise the sentence.

1. As specified by FARA, 33% of residents in West Oakland are at least one mile away from any supermarket, and one-third of **its** residents do not have vehicles.
2. Given the facts above, one can reasonably assume that if people don't have a car and need to take a bus to access healthy food, **it** will cause inconvenience and lower their willingness to purchase healthy food.
3. Food hubs supply fresh vegetables and fruits to low-income communities, and **it** increases access to healthy foods for residents of West Oakland.
4. They think this because there are many corner liquor stores nearby, and **that** is convenient for them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is a paragraph I wrote: [paste]. Is the voice academic? Point out personal or conversational sentences and help me rewrite them in the third person."
- "Underline every pronoun in my paragraph [paste] and tell me its antecedent. Which references are unclear, and how should I fix them?"
- "Let's discuss Amanda Wu's draft. Ask me what its strengths are and what she should revise first, and tell me whether you agree with my priorities."
- "Help me rewrite excerpt 1 from Exercise 2 in an academic voice, but in a different way from excerpt 2."

Read aloud

Pause at each |.

1. Expressing your ideas clearly and with your audience in mind | is central to effective communication.
2. This phe·NOM·e·non has become especially evident | as people pay more attention to a healthy diet | and lean towards purchasing healthy food.
3. A food desert is an area | where there is a lack of fresh vegetable and fruit providers, | such as supermarkets or farmers' markets.
4. Make sure each pronoun | has a single, clear antecedent.
5. These researchers are taking another look | at this narrative.
6. It's difficult for people of lower so·ci·o·e·co·NOM·ic status | to access healthy food.

Writing task

Write an introduction paragraph of 150-200 words in an academic voice.

1. Choose a topic: access to healthy food in your city or region (the book's theme), or a psychology topic such as why many university students do not get enough sleep, or how stress affects students' memory. Use at least one outside source; for psychology, the free OpenStax "Psychology 2e" textbook is a good start.
2. Include a hook, background information with your source, and a thesis.
3. When you finish, underline every pronoun and draw an arrow to its antecedent.

Checklist:

- Is the voice mostly third person, without personal stories?
- Did you avoid talking about your writing process ("In this paper I will try to...")?
- Does every sentence stay on one main topic?
- Did you use at least one outside source?
- Are your words clear and specific?
- Does every pronoun (it, they, this, these) have one clear antecedent?
- Where two nouns could match a pronoun, did you repeat the noun (these researchers)?
- If you used a question as a hook, does the next sentence connect it to your topic?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1.

1. "Food deserts that exist in places like West Oakland, California, contribute to inequitable health outcomes; however, some solutions are in place to improve this situation." (the last sentence of the introduction)
2. Paragraph 2: there is a lack of outlets for fresh produce in their community (accessibility: supermarkets are far away, and many residents have no car). Paragraph 3: people of lower socioeconomic status cannot afford high-end organic food (affordability).
3. Many residents believe that corner liquor stores are cheaper and more convenient than supermarkets. **However** introduces this perspective; **Admittedly, it is true** concedes it; Amanda responds with Sam Bloch's evidence that most corner stores have no walk-in refrigerators, then draws her conclusions with **Thus**, **As a result** and **Hence, even if...**
4. Food hubs (for example, Mandela Foods Distribution, which delivers fresh fruits and vegetables to corner stores in West Oakland) and community gardens (for example, City Slicker Farms).
5. Any two: "...may be not easy to achieve" (correct word order: may not be easy); "people who consistently consume processed food may negatively affect their health"; "they may be associated with some diseases, such as diabetes and heart disease"; "These may be the best ways..."

Exercise 2. (book) Excerpt 2. Both start with a hook (questions that interest the reader). Excerpt 1 then continues with a personal story in the first person, and although this experience is related, it is not exactly the same topic, so the main idea is unclear. Excerpt 2 continues in the third person, the information is unified around one topic, and it clearly relates back to the opening questions. Excerpt 2 is a revised version of excerpt 1.

Exercise 3.

1. Sentence 1: It in "It's difficult" has no antecedent; it is an empty subject that points forward to "to access healthy food". Who refers to people of lower socioeconomic status, and their refers to the same people (people of lower socioeconomic status who live in food deserts). These references are clear. Sentence 3 contains no pronouns, so there is no pronoun problem.
2. (example answer) In sentence 3, Amanda could explain ERS (the Economic Research Service) and remove the comma before "and the number of households", so that the two parts of the measure are clear. Later in the paragraph, its in "one-third of its residents" and it in "it will cause inconvenience" are unclear (Exercise 4).

Exercise 4. (the revisions are example answers)

1. Its should refer to West Oakland, but the closest singular noun is "any supermarket". Revision: ...and one-third of West Oakland's residents do not own vehicles.
2. It has no noun antecedent; it means the whole situation of taking a bus to buy food. Revision: ...if people don't have a car and need to take a bus to buy healthy food, the trip will be inconvenient, and they will be less willing to purchase healthy food.

3. It is singular, but it should refer to food hubs (plural) or to their supply of produce. ("They" would not be clear either, because low-income communities is the closest plural noun.) Revision: By supplying fresh vegetables and fruits to low-income communities, food hubs increase access to healthy food for residents of West Oakland.
4. That refers to a whole idea (that many stores are nearby), not to a noun. Revision: Residents think this because the many corner liquor stores nearby make shopping convenient.

My notes